KIAN WILLIAMS

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Citizenship: United States, Luxembourg (EU)

Education

London School of Economics, London, UK *2025–2026*
MSc Development Management, Track in Applied Development Economics, Distinction
- Dissertation: "Borrowed Ground: Land Sharing as Insurance against Drought in Rural Tanzania"
- Coursework: Advanced Microeconomic Analysis, Applied Econometrics for Development, Applied Policy Analysis for Macroeconomic Development

Sciences Po, Paris School of International Affairs, Paris, France *2024–2025*
Master in International Economic Policy, Concentration in Methods
- Coursework: Advanced Econometrics with Panel Data, Maths for Economists, Evaluating Social Programs: Randomized Experiments, Impact Evaluation of Public Policies, Applied Econometrics with Stata, Classification and Machine Learning for Social Research, International Macroeconomics, International Trade

Haverford College, Haverford, PA *2018–2022*
BSc in Economics, Honors in Economics; Concentration in Mathematical Economics; Minors in Mathematics and Political Science
- GPA: 3.9/4.0
- Economics: Econometrics, Macroeconomics, Advanced Microeconomics, Advanced Topics in Economics Game Theory (Natural Justice), Advanced Topics in Growth Theory, Political Economy
- Mathematics: Multivariable Calculus, Linear Algebra, Linear Optimization, Abstract Algebra I, Abstract Algebra II, Economic Statistics with Calculus

Research

Working Papers

"The Arab Slave Trade and the Diffusion of Islam in Africa" (with Lydia Assouad and Giulia Buccione)
Presented at: **NBER Economics of Religion Conference** (November 2026)

We show that the Arab slave trade spread Islam in Africa through an incentive in Quranic law to convert to avoid enslavement, and that this origin shaped the norms the religion took on among exposed groups. Identification uses variation in slave-raiding exposure across Murdock homelands with exogenous geographic and historic characteristics, linked to folklore catalogues, newly digitized historical mosque data, and present-day survey microdata.

Work in Progress

"Borrowed Ground: Land Sharing as Insurance against Drought in Rural Tanzania" LSE MSc Dissertation

Using Tanzania's National Panel Survey and gridded rainfall data, I show that customary land sharing expands when drought hits, flows toward the most vulnerable households, and so acts as risk-sharing where formal markets for insurance are absent.

Research Experience

CEMFI, Madrid, Spain *Aug 2026 – Present*
Pre-Doctoral Researcher

With Prof. Giulia Buccione and Prof. Emma Smith (Georgetown), on the effects of household water rationing on cognitive and labor outcomes in Amman, Jordan:
- Managed the second round of field data collection; built a GIS dashboard over the sampling frame to check balance across zone borders and flag threats to validity early.
- Processed the survey data, including scoring tablet-based cognitive tasks (Flanker, digit-symbol, memory) and matching GPS and administrative data to surveyed households.
- Estimated spatial RDDs (border-pair fixed effects, fuzzy RDD, wild cluster bootstrap) and household event studies around the delivery cycle; ran heterogeneity analyses to test mechanisms. Helped draft the working paper.

With Prof. Tom Zohar, on the Dutch arm of a multi-country study decomposing intergenerational income mobility into individual and firm components:
- Built the analysis panels from raw administrative files: linked employer–employee wage records, parent–child links, education, and childhood residence, with documented sample definitions and attrition.
- Estimate AKM firm pay premia with the Kline–Saggio–Sølvsten leave-out correction and Bonhomme–Lamadon–Manresa k-means clustering; identified construction choices driving results and proposed fixes.
- Coordinate with the other country teams to harmonize definitions (earnings, thresholds, cohorts, parental income) across datasets.

STICERD, London School of Economics, London, UK *Nov 2025 – Aug 2026*
Research Assistant to Prof. Lydia Assouad; also to Profs. Giulia Buccione and Emma Smith on the Amman project (continued at CEMFI, above)

- Joined as a research assistant on a project studying the long-run effects of the Arab slave trade on the spread and practice of Islam in Africa; became a coauthor on the resulting paper.
- Built the ethnic-group-level dataset linking historical slave-raiding exposure on Murdock homelands to folklore catalogues and present-day survey microdata.
- Identified and constructed geospatial and historical covariates (great-circle distances to historical ports and trade routes, tsetse suitability, human mobility, etc.) for IV analysis and analyses of the mechanisms behind our findings.
- Led the main analysis and robustness work: wild cluster bootstrap, Conley standard errors and spatial-noise placebos, Oster and Lee bounds, coefficient stability to controls, random-effects weighting, leave-one-group-out checks, and other context-specific inference.

IHEAL, Sorbonne Nouvelle University, Paris, France *May 2025 – Aug 2025*
Research Assistant to Prof. Vera Chiodi

- Used difference-in-differences to evaluate the impact of COVID-19 on student learning outcomes in Argentina. Ran robustness and placebo tests and contributed to drafting the working paper.

Rural Support Programmes Network (RSPN), Pakistan, via LSE *Oct 2025 – Jun 2026*
Graduate Student Consultant

- Evaluated the rollout of the Husband Schools program, which provides family-planning education and encourages take-up of public healthcare in rural Pakistan, for Pakistan's largest development network.
- Designed a survey instrument on family planning and health-service use for field enumerators and analyzed program effects on fertility and health-service take-up. Invited to present the findings to RSPN's Board of Directors.

Professional Experience

Compass Lexecon, Boston, MA *Aug 2022 – Aug 2024*
Analyst (2022–2023), Senior Analyst (2023–2024)

- Designed and estimated econometric models supporting expert testimony in major U.S. antitrust litigation; used natural experiments and both proprietary and public data to test damages hypotheses.
- Cleaned and analyzed large transaction-level datasets in Stata and R; drafted sections of expert reports.
- Mentored junior analysts in econometrics and Stata.

Econsult Solutions, Philadelphia, PA *May 2020 – Jul 2022*
Research Analyst (part-time during college)

- Performed economic impact analyses for infrastructure, education, and healthcare projects in R and IMPLAN; authored reports on municipal broadband and subsidized public education and drafted federal grant proposals.

Federal Reserve Bank of San Francisco, San Francisco, CA *May 2021 – Dec 2021*
Intern, Large Financial Institutions

- Built dashboards of regulatory compliance data for large financial institutions and applied linear programming to allocate examiner skills across teams.

Bahá'í Lotus Temple, New Delhi, India *Nov 2017 – Feb 2018*
Tour Guide

- Guided groups through the temple in English and French; on some days more than 100,000 visitors passed through.

Teaching

Haverford College, *Jan 2021 – May 2021*
Teaching Assistant, Intermediate Microeconomics (Prof. Vladimir Kontorovich): led weekly TA sessions; graded problem sets and exams

Skills

Languages: English (native), French (C1), Spanish (C1), Farsi (B2)
Software: Stata, R, Python, QGIS, LaTeX, Excel
Interests: Photography, cycling, surfing, piano, chess, cooking, memoirs

References

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